Struggle for Reform

A grammar of shares, rules, founders, and the shape of durable change

Macharia Barii

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Every Sunday evening, somewhere, a family has the same argument. The weekend is nearly gone. One person wants to see friends; another wants to rest; a third wants to finish a project that has been waiting for weeks. Nobody is being unreasonable. Nobody wants to hurt anybody. And yet the evening cannot be spent three ways. The hours are few. The desires are many. The argument is not about who loves whom. It is about how a scarce thing—time—will be divided.

Now move to a different room. A company's leadership meets to allocate next year's budget. Three divisions want the same capital. Each has a case. Each case is partly true. The money is finite. The meeting is tense.

Now move to a different scale. A country's legislature fights over a budget. Parties, regions, and factions each claim a share of what the state can spend. The fight is loud, procedural, and old.

These scenes feel different. They differ in scale, in stakes, in the language used. But they have the same skeleton. In each, people are making claims on a share of something scarce. In each, the claims contend: satisfying one makes satisfying another harder. In each, the contention produces struggle—effort, argument, maneuvering, sometimes open conflict. And in each, rules determine who ends up with what.

That skeleton—share, claim, contention, struggle, rules—is the subject of this essay. But it is not the whole of it. Behind every set of rules is a foundation: the settlement that no prior rule settles. Behind every foundation is a founder: the person, group, or process that laid it. And beneath the foundation—so often unspoken—is a rigging: the initial advantage that the founding confers on some over others, an advantage that tends to preserve itself. This is the deepest layer, and it is the layer most people never see.

The struggle to change this deepest layer is the struggle for reform. And the word itself is the key. To reform is to re- form — to give a new form to something, to change its shape, to restore or transform its structure. The object of the verb is the form. A reform that leaves the form intact is not a reform; it is a reallocation. A reform that changes the form is a re-founding, even if it happens gradually, legally, and without a shot fired.

This essay is about the struggle for reform in this strict sense. It is about why some reforms succeed and most fail short. And it turns out that the answer is buried in the word itself.

Key idea. Reform means to re-form: to give the foundation a new shape. A reform that leaves the form intact is only a reallocation; one that changes the form is a re-founding.

The four words

Share

A share is the portion of something valuable that someone receives, keeps, or controls. It is what we also call a reward, a portion, a stake—what someone gets. A wage is a share of a firm's revenue. A child's hour of screen time is a share of the household's attention. A country's territory is a share of the earth. A grade is a share of the credit a course offers. A seat on a committee is a share of authority. A share need not be money. It can be time, attention, status, legitimacy, information, safety, or the chance to be heard.

Claim

A claim is what a person asserts, demands, proposes, or tries in order to obtain, keep, or enlarge a share. A bid is a claim on a good. A move in chess is a claim on a square. A budget request is a claim on funds. A knock on someone's door is a claim on their attention. Claims can be compatible—two people can both get what they ask for. They can be incompatible—only one can win. Or they can be partly compatible, so that satisfying one reduces but does not eliminate another.

Contention

Contention is the pivotal idea, and it is easy to miss because the word sounds like fighting. But contention is not yet a fight. It is the condition in which two or more claims bear on the same share, so that satisfying one affects the satisfaction of another. Contention is the situation that makes a fight possible. It is structural, not behavioral. A quiet office where two people want the same promotion is full of contention even if no one has said a word.

Rival, cooperative, coordinative

Contention comes in flavors. Some is rival: one person's share grows at another's expense. Some is cooperative: each person's share grows when the other's does. And some is coordinative: both parties want to agree on a joint arrangement, but neither cares much about the other's share per se—they only care that the arrangement be shared.

This three-way distinction is not academic. It is the difference between a marriage and a merger, between an alliance and a rivalry, between a standard and a contest. Most human relationships contain all three at once, in different proportions, over different things. Recognizing which is which is the beginning of strategy.

Struggle

A struggle is the activity of contending—the effort, time, risk, and resources people expend trying to secure, defend, or enlarge a share. Contention is the structure; struggle is the process. A union negotiating a contract is struggling. A firm cutting prices is struggling. A person resisting the pull of their phone to finish a piece of work is struggling.

Struggle has a grammar, and the grammar is revealing. English—and many other languages—let us say three things:

- We struggle for something: independence, market share, a place in the life we want.
- We struggle with someone against a common obstacle: our shared struggle for recognition, for justice, for survival.
- We struggle over something: the terms of a contract, the rules of an institution, the direction of a movement.

These three prepositions are not accidents of speech. They map directly onto the three kinds of contention. Struggle for is rival contention. Struggle with is cooperative contention. Struggle over is coordinative contention. The grammar of struggle encodes the structure of contention. When you hear someone say "the struggle over the rules," you are

listening to people who understand, perhaps without knowing it, that the deepest conflicts are not about shares but about the arrangements that determine shares.

Key idea. Contention is the structure; struggle is the process. Struggle *for*, *with*, and *over* trace rival, cooperative, and coordinative contention.

Rules: the fifth word, and the deepest

That brings us to the fifth word, the one that often decides everything: rules.

What rules are

Rules are the arrangements that determine how claims become shares. They include the formal—contracts, laws, constitutions, auctions, voting systems—and the informal—norms, conventions, expectations, habits. A market's price mechanism is a rule. A firm's budgeting process is a rule. A family's unspoken understanding about who handles bedtime is a rule. A constitution is a rule of rules.

Rules shape the struggle

Rules matter because they determine which struggles take place and how shares are assigned once claims are made. Change the rule and you change the struggle. A promotion decided by seniority produces a different contest than one decided by performance review, which produces a different contest than one decided by a coin flip. None of these rules is neutral. Each favors some claimants and disadvantages others. Each produces its own kind of effort, its own kind of resentment, its own kind of peace.

Struggle over the rules

And so we arrive at the deepest form of contention, the one that runs beneath all the others: struggle over the rules. When people fight over a budget, they are fighting within the rules. When they fight over how the budget is decided— who sits on the committee, what the voting threshold is, what counts as a valid claim—they are fighting over the rules themselves. This is the struggle that shapes all subsequent struggles.

Three questions to ask

A useful habit of mind follows from this. When you encounter a conflict, ask two questions in order. First: what is the share being contended? Second: what are the rules that determine who gets it? The first question is what most people ask. The second is what strategists ask. And a third question, rarer still: who decided the rules, and how?

> **Key idea.** Change the rule and you change the struggle. The deepest conflicts are not over shares but over the arrangements that decide shares.

Who decided the rules?

The problem of first allocation

There is a question that follows immediately from the last section, and it is the question the framework cannot answer. If rules determine how claims become shares, then who decided the rules?

And who decided who decides?

This is the problem of first allocation. It is the problem of the allocation that no prior rule allocates—the allocation of rule-making authority itself. Every order has one, and none can justify it by its own rules.

The regress stops at the foundation

The regress is simple. If the rules were chosen under some rule, then that rule was chosen under another, and so on. Either the chain goes on forever—rules all the way down, with nothing at the bottom—or it stops somewhere. It stops at the foundation of the order: the settlement that is not itself settled by any prior rule. A constitution is a foundation. A company's charter is a foundation. A marriage is a foundation. The conditions you were born into are a foundation. Each is the bottom of its own order, the place where the regress of rules runs out.

The founder

The foundation is laid by a founder—the one who establishes the first rules. The founder may be a person: a conqueror, a constitution-writer, an entrepreneur, a parent. It may be a group: a constituent assembly, a founding partnership, a household. It may be a process: a community gradually converging on a practice. Or it may be no one at all: history, drift, accident. The founder is the answer to who decided. The mode of founding is the answer to how.

Four ways a foundation is laid

There are four ways a foundation can be laid.

- **Force.** The founder imposes the rules. A revolution, a coup, a conquest, a founder's fiat.
- **Agreement.** The founders consent to the rules. A constitution, a charter, a compact, a marriage vow.

- **Convention.** The rules emerge from practice. No one decides; people follow a pattern, and the pattern hardens into a rule.
- **Accident.** The rules are the residue of history. Path dependence, inheritance, drift.

The legitimacy deficit

Each of these is a way of founding an order. None of them is fully legitimate by the standards of the order it founds. Force is not legitimate. Agreement is hypothetical or incomplete. Convention is not chosen. Accident is not justified. This is not a reason for cynicism. It is a reason for clarity. It is why constitutions have founding myths, why firms have origin stories, why families have unspoken understandings about who decided what.

Key idea. Every order rests on a foundation—the settlement no prior rule settles—and no foundation can justify itself by its own rules.

Is the game rigged?

The rigged foundation

A foundation is not neutral. Whoever lays it lays it with their interests in mind—or with their interests encoded in the accidents of history that laid it. The first allocation is also an allocation of advantage. We call this the rigged foundation: the initial advantage that the founding confers on some players over others.

Explicit and implicit advantage

The advantage can be explicit. A constitution that requires property ownership for the vote. A company charter that gives founders ten votes per share. An inheritance rule that favors one child over another. Or it can be implicit. First- mover advantages that compound over time. Information asymmetries between the founder and later players. The simple fact that the status quo is harder to change than it is to defend.

Self-reinforcement

A rigged foundation is usually self-reinforcing. The people it advantages are given—or can acquire—the procedural rights to block reforms that would reduce their advantage. A veto. A supermajority requirement. Agenda control. The rules that would allow reform are controlled by the people who would be reformed.

Who struggles least

There is a corollary that is easy to miss. In a rigged order, the beneficiaries struggle less than the disadvantaged. The rules already favor them, so they have little to struggle for within the rules. The disadvantaged struggle constantly, because they must struggle not only against other claimants but against the rules themselves. This is why rigged orders often look calm on the surface: the people doing the struggling are the people whose struggles are least visible.

Erosion

This does not mean the advantage is permanent. The beneficiary coalition can fragment. New players can accumulate the resources the rules depend on. The rules can be reinterpreted by later readers. A rigged foundation erodes, given enough time and enough change. But erosion is slow, uncertain, and often blocked precisely by the self-reinforcing mechanisms. So the practical claim stands: within-rules reform usually fails against a self-reinforcing rigging, and this is why de-rigging, when it happens, tends to happen by refounding rather than reform.

Key idea. A rigged foundation is self-reinforcing: the rules that would allow reform are controlled by the people who would be reformed.

The game is never zero-sum

What zero-sum means

Zero-sum means: what I gain, you lose, and nothing else changes. It is the logic of a fixed pie. A negotiation over the price of a house. A tennis match. A budget that has already been set.

The founder advantage is not a slice

But a game with a live founder advantage can never be purely zero-sum. Here is why.

A founder advantage is not a slice of the pie. It is a feature of how the pie is cut and how big it is. The founder did not win the game; the founder laid the field. And laying the field is not a move in the game—it is the condition of the game.

Two levels

This means the game has two levels. At the first level, players play within the rules. That level can be zero-sum: a fixed budget, a fixed market, a fixed amount of attention. At the second level, players struggle over the rules themselves. That level is never zero-sum, because the rules determine the size of the pie, not just its division.

The meta-game

The founder advantage is the trace of the second level in the first. It is evidence that the rules were laid by someone, in some mode, in someone's favor. And the existence of that someone—the founder—means the game has a meta- game.

Why zero-sum thinking fails

This is why zero-sum thinking is so often a mistake. It is the thinking of players who take the foundation for granted. It is not always wrong—sometimes you really are playing a fixed game, and you should fight for your slice. But the most important games are not fixed. They are laid, and they can be laid differently.

The slogan

A useful slogan: zero-sum is the arithmetic of players who cannot see the foundation. The framework's insistence on the first allocation is, in part, an insistence that the arithmetic is usually incomplete.

> **Key idea.** Zero-sum is the arithmetic of players who cannot see the foundation; the struggle over the rules is never zero-sum.

Four words, not one

Splitting rigging into four

The word "rigging" is doing a lot of work in this essay, and it needs to be split into four. The distinctions matter, because most reforms fail because they confuse them.

Foundation rigging

Foundation rigging is the original sin. It is the advantage that the founding confers on the founder's coalition — laid into the foundation at the moment of founding, structural, persistent. The Three-Fifths Compromise is a foundation rigging. Dual-class stock is a foundation rigging. The inheritance rule that favors the eldest son is a foundation rigging.

Re-rigging

Re-rigging is the replacement of one foundation rigging with another. The old elite is removed; a new elite is installed; the structure that produced the rigging is intact. The French Revolution's succession of constitutions was a series of re-riggings. The post-colonial transitions in many states were re-riggings. The corporate recapitalization that strips the founder's shares and gives the new CEO a golden parachute is a re-rigging. The old advantage is gone; the new one is in its place.

De-rigging

De-rigging is the removal of a specific foundation rigging. It is what the disadvantaged coalition seeks. The abolition of the Three-Fifths Compromise was a de-rigging. The corporate governance reform that abolishes dual-class stock is a de-rigging. The family decision to divide the inheritance equally is a de-rigging. It removes the current advantage.

Anti-rigging

Anti-rigging is the structural design that makes future foundation rigging harder. It is not the removal of a specific advantage (that is de-rigging). It is the change in the terms of laying — the structural conditions under which foundations are made and maintained. The Bill of Rights of 1689 was an anti-rigging. The U.S. Constitution's separation of powers is an anti-rigging. The corporate governance reform that establishes independent directors, audit committees, and shareholder voting is an anti-rigging.

The 2×2 matrix

The four concepts form a 2×2 matrix:

De-rigging No de-rigging Anti-rigging Durable de-rigging Partial anti-rigging No anti-rigging Fragile de-rigging Re-rigging

The matrix is the conceptual core of the theory. Every revolution, every reform, every constitutional convention, every corporate reorganization, every family rupture can be placed in one of its four cells. And the cell predicts its durability.

The failure modes and the goal

Fragile de-rigging is the most common failure mode. The revolution removes the old advantage but does not anti-rig. The revolutionary coalition has the power to lay a new advantage, and the framework predicts it will. The result is a re- rigging, often within a generation. The French Revolution is the paradigm case. So is the Russian Revolution. So is most of what we call revolutionary history.

Partial anti-rigging is the second failure mode. The reform includes anti-rigging provisions but does not remove the old advantage. The old rigging persists, but future rigging is harder. This is better than fragile de-rigging, but it leaves the old injustice in place.

Re-rigging is the failure mode where the old advantage is replaced by a new one. The structure of the game is unchanged. The players have changed.

Durable de-rigging is the goal. It requires both: the removal of the old advantage and the structural provisions that make future rigging harder. The Glorious Revolution of 1688 is the paradigm case. The American Constitution is another. The post-war German constitution is a third.

The distinction between these four concepts is the most important thing the framework has to say about reform. It explains why most reforms fail short: they de-rig without anti-rigging. And it specifies what a durable reform would require: de-rigging and anti-rigging together, with self-limitation as the test of the reforming coalition's seriousness.

> **Key idea.** Most reforms fail short because they de-rig without anti-rigging: they remove the old advantage but not the form that produced it.

The word itself

Etymology: re-formare

The word reform is doing more work than it first appears. It comes from the Latin reformare — to form again, to restore to a former shape, to transform. The object of the verb is the form. To reform something is not to improve it

within its existing shape. It is to give it a new shape.

Reform is a fight over the form

This is why the struggle for reform is not the same as the struggle for shares. A fight over the budget is not a reform; it is a reallocation. A fight over the promotion is not a reform; it is a

substitution. A fight over the election is not a reform; it is a competition. A reform is a fight over the form — the rules, the foundation, the terms on which the shares are allocated.

The distinction has been with us all along, buried in the word. The theory makes it explicit. The struggle for reform is the struggle to re-form — to lay a new foundation, or to change the terms on which the old one is laid. Everything else is a fight within the rules. The reform is a fight over the rules.

The word covers four operations: re-forming the foundation (the strict sense), removing an advantage (de-rigging), adding provisions to the foundation without removing the advantage (anti-rigging within the rules), and replacing one advantage with another (re-rigging). Only one of these — re-forming the foundation with anti-rigging — is durable. The others fail short, often within a generation.

> **Key idea.** To reform is to re-form. A reform is a fight over the form; everything else—reallocation, substitution, competition—is a fight within the rules.

Why most reforms fail

The framework gives four reasons why most reforms fail, and they are structural, not moral.

Reason one: a coalition of claimants

The reforming coalition is a coalition of claimants. A revolution is not made by a single actor. It is made by a coalition — sometimes an alliance of classes, sometimes an alliance of factions. The coalition agrees on the de-rigging: the old foundation must go. It does not agree on what comes next. The revolutionary coalition that overthrew the French monarchy included the bourgeoisie, the sans-culottes, the peasantry, and the provincial notables. These groups had different interests, different visions, and different claims. The Jacobin dictatorship, the Thermidorian reaction, and the Napoleonic empire were not accidents. They were the resolution of a coalition that could not agree on the terms of the new foundation.

Reason two: the power to rig

The reforming coalition has the power to rig. The coalition that overthrows the old order holds the power to lay the new foundation. It has the arms, the organization, and the legitimacy of victory. The framework predicts that it will write the rules to its own advantage. This is not a moral failing; it is a structural consequence of the situation. The coalition holds the power to rig, and a coalition with the power to rig will use it — because the alternative is to leave itself vulnerable to a future de-rigging.

Reason three: fear of the counter-revolution

The reforming coalition fears the counter-revolution. The reforming coalition is usually surrounded by enemies. The old elite is plotting restoration. Foreign powers may intervene. Internal factions may defect. The coalition feels besieged, and the siege justifies extraordinary measures. The framework predicts that a besieged coalition will entrench itself. It will acquire

emergency powers, suspend normal procedures, and consolidate authority. Each of these is a step toward re-rigging. The siege is real, but the response to the siege is also a re-rigging.

Reason four: not knowing how to anti-rig

The reforming coalition does not know how to anti-rig. Anti-rigging is a design problem, and most reformers are not designers. They know how to overthrow; they do not know how to build. They write constitutions that encode their values and their interests, but they do not write provisions that constrain their own power.

> **Key idea.** Revolutions fall short for structural reasons, not moral ones: they de-rig without anti-rigging, and they re-rig within a generation.

How to make rigging harder

De-rigging and anti-rigging

De-rigging removes an advantage. Anti-rigging prevents a new one from being laid. The distinction is precise: de- rigging says this advantage must go; anti-rigging says the conditions that produced this advantage must change.

The anti-rigging paradox

There is a paradox at the heart of anti-rigging. The reforming coalition is itself a founder. If it makes the anti-rigging provisions strong enough to prevent future rigging, it makes them strong enough to entrench itself. If it makes them weak enough to avoid entrenching itself, it makes them too weak to work. This is the anti-rigging paradox, and it cannot be escaped by good intentions. It can only be escaped by structure.

Self-limitation

The resolution is self-limitation: the reforming coalition binds itself with the same provisions it binds its successors. It says, in effect: we lay these rules to prevent rigging, including our own. The provisions that constrain our successors also constrain us. This does not make the founding fully legitimate — no founding is. But it reduces the legitimacy deficit, because a self-limiting founding does not claim an exemption from the standard it imposes.

Self-limitation in practice

What does self-limitation look like in practice? It looks like provisions that apply to the reformers as effectively as to their successors. The founders' advantages expire on the same schedule as anyone else's. The founders do not hold procedural rights their successors do not hold. The provisions reduce the founders' advantage as much as they reduce any successor's.

This is hard to achieve. It requires the reformers to act against their own interest, which the framework predicts they will not do. So the reforming coalition must be structurally constrained — by a plurality of coalitions with overlapping mandates, each of which can block the others' re-rigging. Self-limitation is not a matter of virtue. It is a matter of structure.

Six families of provisions

What are the structural provisions that make rigging harder? There are six families.

- **Temporal limits.** Sunset clauses, mandatory review, generational accounting. Provisions that allocate advantage expire unless renewed, and renewal requires the consent of those who would be disadvantaged by non-renewal.
- **Concentration limits.** Rotation, sortition, term limits, anti-concentration rules. No coalition holds rule-making authority indefinitely.
- **Transparency.** Disclosure, audit, public reasoning. Allocation decisions are visible to those affected. Rigging flourishes in the dark; it is harder in the light.
- **Entrenchment asymmetry.** Anti-rigging provisions are harder to remove than ordinary rules but not impossible to remove. Too easy to remove, they fail. Too hard to remove, they become a new rigging.
- **Dispersal.** Federalism, separation of powers, overlapping trustees. No single coalition captures all rule-making authority.
- **Contestability.** Legal standing, referendum, recall. Any affected party can challenge allocation decisions.

The portfolio

No single provision is sufficient. A portfolio — at least one from each family — can jointly satisfy the four constraints: it must be effective, functional, legitimate, and self-limiting. The portfolio is the unit of design, not the individual provision.

The nominality problem

The hardest question is whether a provision is effective — whether it actually raises the cost of rigging — or merely nominal. Many anti-rigging provisions are nominal. Sunset clauses that are routinely renewed. Transparency provisions that disclose nothing consequential. Entrenchment that is never tested. This is the nominality problem, and it is the central practical challenge of anti-rigging theory.

There are partial solutions. Multiple triggers. Third-party enforcement. Visible non-compliance. Sunset on the sunset. These are partial. A full solution to the nominality problem is an open research question. But the direction is clear: anti-rigging provisions must be designed to bite, to cost, and to impose asymmetric costs on the rigger. A provision that does not bite is not anti-rigging. It is decoration.

Key idea. The anti-rigging paradox is resolved by self-limitation: the reforming coalition binds itself with the same provisions it binds its successors.

Three reforms, three outcomes

Three cases show the matrix in action.

The Glorious Revolution: durable de-rigging

The Glorious Revolution of 1688 was a durable de-rigging. James II was overthrown. The Catholic monarchy was replaced by a Protestant one. The specific advantage of the old beneficiary coalition — the Catholic aristocracy, the royal prerogative, the dispensing power — was eliminated. But the Glorious Revolution did not stop there. It added anti-rigging: the Bill of Rights of 1689, the Act of Settlement of 1701, the Triennial Act. These provisions established parliamentary supremacy, free elections, freedom of speech in Parliament, and the prohibition of royal interference with the law. They included temporal limits (Parliament had to be summoned regularly), concentration limits (the royal prerogative was curtailed), transparency (parliamentary proceedings were made public), entrenchment asymmetry (the Bill of Rights was made difficult to amend), dispersal (power was dispersed between Crown, Lords, and Commons), and contestability (elections were made free and regular). The anti-rigging applied to the new monarchs as much as to their successors. The result was a structure in which re-rigging was harder than it would have been otherwise. It was not a utopia — the eighteenth-century oligarchy, the nineteenth-century reform movements, and the twentieth-century welfare state were all responses to residual rigging. But it was durable.

The French Revolution: fragile de-rigging

The French Revolution was a fragile de-rigging. The monarchy was overthrown; the aristocracy was abolished; the specific advantage of the old beneficiary coalition was eliminated. But the revolutionary constitutions did not include the anti-rigging provisions that the Glorious Revolution included. There were no temporal limits on the revolutionary government, no concentration limits on the Committee of Public Safety, no transparency provisions for the Jacobin clubs, no entrenchment asymmetry, no dispersal of power across independent bodies, no contestability mechanisms that survived the Terror. The result was predictable: the revolutionaries acquired emergency powers and never gave them up. The Committee of Public Safety became a dictatorship. The Directory became an oligarchy. Napoleon became an emperor. The Bourbon Restoration restored the monarchy. Each of these transitions was a re-rigging.

The Russian Revolution: re-rigging

The Russian Revolution was a re-rigging. The tsarist aristocracy was overthrown; the specific advantage of the old beneficiary coalition was eliminated. But the Bolsheviks did not de-rig in the framework's sense. They replaced one advantage with another. The party elite, the nomenklatura, and the security services acquired procedural rights that were structurally identical to those of the old elite. The rigging changed hands; the structure was intact. There was no anti-rigging. The Bolsheviks concentrated authority in the party, the Politburo, and the secret police. They suppressed opposition, abolished independent courts, and controlled the press. Each of these was a step toward re-rigging. The Soviet Union survived for seventy-four years — longer than the tsarist autocracy that preceded it, and longer than most revolutions. But it did not de-rig; it re-rigged. When it finally collapsed, it collapsed into a new rigging — the oligarchic capitalism of the 1990s — which was structurally identical to the old one.

The pattern

The pattern is clear. The reforms that included both de-rigging and anti-rigging were durable. The reform that included only de-rigging was fragile. The reform that included neither was a re-rigging. The framework predicts this pattern, and the historical record bears it out.

> **Key idea.** Reforms that de-rig and anti-rig are durable; those that do only one are fragile—the difference is in the form, not the spirit.

What to do with it

Six habits

If the framework is useful, it should change how you think about reform. Six habits follow.

1. **Name the share.** When you encounter a conflict, ask what is actually being divided. It is often not what the participants say. A fight about money may be a fight about recognition. A fight about recognition may be a fight about time.

2. **Map the contention.** Ask who is coupled with whom, and over what. Ask whether the coupling is rival, cooperative, or coordinative. Ask which clusters are active and which are latent.

3. **Look at the rules.** Ask what determines how claims become shares. Ask who set the rules and why. Ask whether the rules are the real stakes. They often are.

4. **Look at the foundation.** Ask where the rules themselves came from. Ask who founded the order and in what mode—force, agreement, convention, or accident. Ask what legitimacy deficit the founding carries.

5. **Ask whether the reform is durable.** Ask whether it de-rigs, whether it anti-rigs, whether it is self-limiting. Ask whether it will survive the next generation. The matrix tells you what to look for.

6. **Count the cost.** Ask where your effort is best spent. Ask what you can concede to concentrate on what matters. Reform is finite. Spend it where it counts.

These six habits are not a formula. They are a discipline. They will not tell you what to do. They will help you see what you are doing.

> **Key idea.** The six habits are a discipline, not a formula: they help you see what you are doing, not what to do.

Coda

The family arguing about Sunday evening, the firm fighting over next year's budget, the legislature fighting over the shape of the state — these are not separate phenomena. They are

variations on a single pattern. People make claims on shares. The claims contend. The contention produces struggle. The struggle is shaped by rules. The rules are laid by founders. The founders rest on foundations that no rule can fully justify. And the foundations are usually rigged, in favor of some and against others.

The struggle to change the foundation is the struggle for reform. And the word itself is the key. To reform is to re-form — to give a new form to something. The object of the verb is the form. A reform that leaves the form intact is not a reform. It is a reallocation. A reform that changes the form is a re-founding.

Most reforms fail short because they de-rig without anti-rigging. They remove the old advantage but do not change the form that produced it. The result is a re-rigging, often within a generation. The French Revolution and the Russian Revolution are the paradigm cases. The Glorious Revolution and the American Constitution are the exceptions, because they combined de-rigging with anti-rigging.

The lesson is not a counsel of despair. It is a counsel of design. A reform that de-rigs and anti-rigs is durable. A reform that does only one is fragile. The difference is in the form, not in the spirit. And form can be designed.

The deepest change is not winning within the rules. It is laying new foundations — which is what every reformer, every constitution, every fresh start has always been. The field can be relaid. But a relaying that does not change the terms of laying merely resets the board for the next founder. The question is not only whose advantage should be removed but what structure should make the next advantage harder to lay.

The game is played on a field that someone laid, and the laying of the field is not itself a move in the game. But it is the most consequential thing that ever happens in it. And the struggle to lay it differently — the struggle for reform — is the oldest, the deepest, and the most consequential political activity there is.

Key idea. The struggle for reform is the struggle to lay the field differently—the oldest, deepest, and most consequential political activity there is.